

Creativity at Work

Interdisciplinary learning in
industry and community settings

August 2021



Acknowledgements

The Australia Council for the Arts and the Queensland University of Technology proudly acknowledge all First Nations peoples and their rich culture of the country we now call Australia. We pay respect to Elders past and present. We acknowledge First Nations peoples as Australia's First Peoples and as the Traditional Owners and custodians of the lands and waters on which we live.

We recognise and value the ongoing contribution of First Nations peoples and communities to Australian life, and how this continuation of 75,000 years of unbroken storytelling enriches us. We embrace the spirit of reconciliation, working towards ensuring an equal voice and the equality of outcomes in all aspects of our society.

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Foreword

Creative practitioners are highly skilled professionals with capabilities developed through lifelong learning and deep immersion in developing their art form practice. Creative practitioners also face a range of challenges in making a living. And yet their ability to address such challenges is part of what makes them so valuable.

Creatives are often drawn to the unfamiliar: they seek out the strange and the new. Artists come at problems with clever and unexpected ideas. They are curious. It is for all these reasons that creativity is increasingly recognised as essential to 21st century workforces, and indeed for facing wider uncertainties regarding the future.

Creativity at Work: Interdisciplinary learning in industry and community settings seeks to better understand the evolving contexts for creativity and how to best prepare graduates for work in the creative industries. Produced by researchers in QUT's Creative Industries Faculty and the Australia Council for the Arts, it reports on a study of QUT's Situated Creative Practice program in its pilot year.

The joint authorship of this report is testament to the highly collaborative way in which the Australia Council and QUT Creative Industries have worked together on this research. Each sector – arts agencies on the one hand, and higher education in the arts – faces similar imperatives.

For arts agencies, it is to help set up artists for the challenges and opportunities of professional creative practice, acknowledging that for many this practice will involve working across different art forms and even across different industries.

For higher education in the arts, it is to ready students with burning creative ambition and potential for the realities of contemporary workplaces and career pathways. Situated Creative Practice is one of QUT's responses to that challenge. It is a component of a broader commitment to work-integrated learning (WIL) – now a major feature of pedagogy and curriculum throughout the Australian university system.

Creativity at Work both analyses the pilot program and explores the benefits of the transferable creative skills that are key to the Situated Creative Practice design.

This is early work, but work that must continue if we are to identify the new and evolving ways that artists can be rewarded for their skills, and so prepare artists for social, economic and technological change. Even in the year of our study, the COVID-19 pandemic emphasised the vulnerability of many arts and educational institutions, upending many institutional and workplace norms and requiring rapid adaptation by organisations and individuals.

The pandemic has forced the question of how we might make the cultural and creative sector more resilient. It has also made *Creativity at Work* all the more relevant, highlighting the need for lateral and adaptive approaches in preparing for creative careers.

Adrian Collette AM
Chief Executive Officer
Australia Council

Stuart Cunningham
Distinguished Emeritus Professor
Creative Industries
QUT

Key terms

‘Credit points’ refers to the number of points assigned to a unit, study area or complementary studies that count towards the enrolment load and total points to complete a course. Credit points are also an indicator of the amount of work the unit might entail.

‘Interdisciplinary’ refers to work in which multiple disciplines come together. The term is often divided in the three sub-categories:

multidisciplinary – where multiple disciplines collaborate but practices remain unchanged

interdisciplinary – where there is an attempt to integrate or synthesise perspectives from different disciplines

transdisciplinary – involves ‘transgression against or transcendence of disciplinary norms’.¹

These definitions point to a spectrum: ‘at its weakest, interdisciplinarity constitutes barely more than cooperation, while at its strongest, it lays the foundation for a more transformative recasting of disciplines’.²

‘Unit’ refers to a structured and coherent set of learning activities that normally work in concert with other units to contribute to one or more learning outcomes. At other institutions, this might be referred to as a ‘subject’ or ‘course’.

‘Capstone unit’ refers to a culminating project or course, typically in the final year of students’ academic program.³ A capstone unit allows you to demonstrate what you have learnt and the skills that you have acquired throughout the course of your study.

‘Program’ in this report refers to the Situated Creative Practice program provided as a 48 credit point study package to Bachelor of Fine Art students in the final year of their degree. In completing this program, students must enrol in at least one 24 credit point Situated Creative Practice unit. Within a Situated Creative Practice unit, students will engage in one of a number of active Situated Creative Practice projects.

‘Work integrated learning’ enables students to learn through engagement with industry and community partners in authentic activities. The activities are planned and assessed as part of their course. Work integrated learning may occur on-campus or through virtual environments. In each case, students work individually and/or in disciplinary or interdisciplinary teams with industry and community partners.⁴

1 Barry A, Born G and Wieszkalnys G 2008, ‘Logics of Interdisciplinarity’, *Economy and Society*, 37(1), 20–49.

2 Barry A, Born G and Wieszkalnys G 2008, ‘Logics of Interdisciplinarity’, *Economy and Society*, 37(1), 20–49.

3 The Glossary of Education Reform, viewed 29 July 2021 at <https://www.edglossary.org/capstone-project/>

4 QUT, 2020. Work Integrated Learning, Definition.



Vermilion Records performance set. Credit: Kristina Kelman.

Executive summary

Creative practitioners are increasingly working and applying creative skills in non-creative sectors.⁵ Creativity is also key to the kinds of interdisciplinary approaches that will be required for future work environments.⁶

Together, these trends point to a range of possible career pathways for creative practitioners, and the need to prepare creative graduates for future interdisciplinary work. But is this how students of creative industries view their future professional role – that is, applying their training in areas beyond their traditional arts discipline or focus? How do potential employers understand the value of creativity or the currency of creative skills? And **what educational models are required to prepare students for complex creative work in interdisciplinary settings?**

This report presents the findings of a joint research project by the Australia Council and QUT's Faculty of Creative Industries that investigated **the role and value of interdisciplinary work integrated learning for creative industries students**. The research focussed on projects run within the QUT School of Creative Practice capstone study program, **Situated Creative Practice**, as delivered across its pilot phase.

Situated Creative Practice is project-based, **requiring students to situate their specialist creative practice in industry or community contexts**. The program focuses on building students' capacity in creative and critical thinking, problem solving, social intelligence, communication, resource management, and entrepreneurial and technological skills. The overarching goal of Situated Creative Practice is to **provide a training ground for interdisciplinary skills development, for work across contexts beyond one traditional art form, and to provide graduates with the capabilities required to work in multidisciplinary creative teams**.

- 5 Trembath J L and Fielding K 2020, 'Australia's Cultural and Creative Economy: A 21st century guide', produced by A New Approach think tank with lead delivery partner the Australian Academy of the Humanities, Canberra. Bureau of Communications and Arts Research (BCAR) 2020, 'Cultural and Creative Activity in Australia 2008–09 to 2017–18', Explanatory Notes, Canberra: Department of Communications and the Arts. Throsby D and Petetskaya K 2017, *Making Art Work: An economic study of professional artists in Australia*.
- 6 World Economic Forum 2016, *What are the 21st-Century Skills Every Student Needs?* Easton E and Djumalieva J 2018, *Creativity and the Future of Skills*. Cunningham S, Theilacker M, Gahan P, Callan V and Rannie A 2016, *Skills and Capabilities for Australian Enterprise Innovation*.

This research was conducted between August 2019 to June 2020, with a focus on seven Situated Creative Practice projects as case studies. Data was collected from **student assessments and surveys**, and through **20 semi-structured interviews** with Situated Creative Practice students, academics and industry partners. Collectively, the research sought to understand **the value of participation in Situated Creative Practice** for students, staff and industry partners; **challenges and successes of the pilot program**; and both **industry and student expectations regarding preparation for work in the creative industries**.

Value of Participation in Situated Creative Practice – for students, staff and industry partners

While the development of deep art form knowledge and creative skills remains critical, interdisciplinary work integrated learning provides benefits for the students as well as industry partners. Benefits of the program include:

- **Students' development of networking and collaboration skills**, and the opportunity for students to learn about other disciplines.
- **The connection of students with a local creative network**, and an understanding of the local creative scene.
- **Accelerated learning** for both academic staff and students. Many reported that the experience of Situated Creative Practice was challenging compared to a more traditional, advanced disciplinary curriculum. However, rather than these challenges inhibiting learning, they enhanced it.
- **New skills and fresh ideas for partners**, linking industry to the cutting edge of artistic practice or creative thinking.
- **Strengthened relationships between the creative and educational sectors**, ensuring that students have the appropriate skills for employment following graduation.

Challenges and successes of the pilot program

Challenges encountered within the Situated Creative Practice's pilot phase included:

- Some **resistance to the interdisciplinary focus** of the program, particularly among students less progressed in their study and/or with less creative industry experience.
- **Concern** from some staff and students that the program **might reduce students' ability to fit discipline-based arts training into the formal curriculum**.
- The need to manage **student expectations of their university experience and future careers** alongside the actual requirements of professional creative practice.
- **Limits on organisational capacity for industry partners**. It was sometimes difficult to develop realistic opportunities for students, or to provide meaningful opportunities for students that aligned with the aims of Situated Creative Practice.

Opportunities to address these challenges include:

- The **development of strong advocates for the program at QUT**, particularly among staff and students with recent experience working in the creative sector.
- The **development of meaningful partnerships between university and industry**, producing strong external advocates for the Situated Creative Practice program.
- A proven **ability of the program to flex and adapt, particularly in the context of COVID-19** and the pandemic's impact on the university and creative sectors (see box to the right).

Expectations regarding preparation for work in the creative industries

While expectations regarding preparation for work in the creative industries were mixed within the university context – with some unsure of the value of interdisciplinary training – industry partners generally supported the design of the Situated Creative Practice program. Partners highlighted the importance of:

- Skills such as **creative and critical thinking, collaboration skills**.
- Curiosity, and an **openness to new learning experiences**, or 'lifelong learning'.
- The need for students to have a **knowledge of 'the business' of the creative sector**, e.g. common organisational structures, budgets, funding models, grant writing, and where to find legal resources.
- **Training in a specific art form and relevant technology**. In addition to having interdisciplinary skills, students should also understand the technical and theoretical underpinnings of their creative practice.

Conclusions

Prior to this research, the designers of Situated Creative Practice consulted with industry to ascertain their perceptions of creative industries graduates. While employers had confidence in graduates' disciplinary skills, there was less awareness of broader graduate capabilities that can be applied within other contexts. For example, **prospective employers lacked awareness of graduate capabilities related to interdisciplinary teamwork, business management and entrepreneurialism, complex problem solving, communication, and understanding audiences**.

The Situated Creative Practice pilot responded directly to this lack of awareness, seeking to both publicise and extend student learning in these specific areas. However, key lessons of this research suggest that there remains a **need to focus on ways to translate between different organisational lexicons**. This includes translating the values, practices, and skills of creative industries into the languages of other sectors, as well as translating the languages of specific art forms into that of the creative industries more generally.

Future programs would benefit by recognising this capability to translate values between different sectors and systems as a fundamental requirement for the program's success. **It is also imperative that academic staff in charge of such programs model this type of transdisciplinarity within their own institutions**, so as to broker value between academic staff, other university staff, industry partners and students.



Adapting to COVID-19

As a result of the pandemic, Situated Creative Practice rapidly moved online in Semester 1 2020, and continued to reimagine project outcomes as the year progressed.

A traditional live theatre production was shifted to remote rehearsals and performances facilitated via Zoom. A series of participatory, arts-based community workshops were moved to online delivery. And in another example, a slate of ten-minute documentary films, originally planned to be filmed on-site throughout Southeast Queensland, was transformed into a series of student-made documentaries on life in COVID lockdown filmed remotely in students' individual homes.

In each of these instances, students, academic staff, and industry partners were able to rapidly adjust the outcomes of projects because they were supported by a consistent curriculum focus on the *process* of interdisciplinary collaboration. In this way, **the crisis accentuated the importance of the types of capabilities Situated Creative Practice set out to develop.**

1:1 student project at the Ars Electronica Festival 2017. Credit: James Dillon.

Introduction

Student interactive media performance, QUT 2019.
Credit: Kylie Zenchyson.

The nature of work is rapidly changing. Across sectors, **workplaces are being transformed by new business models and disruptive technologies**, requiring employees to adapt and collaborate with new colleagues and areas of expertise. Increasing digitisation, changing consumer models and increasing competition for resources are demanding that organisations remain agile, working harder to maintain their relevance and remaining open to new ways of getting things done.

These conditions are similarly transforming the creative industries. Research indicates that **creative practitioners are increasingly working in non-creative sectors**.⁷ According to the **'creative trident'**, developed by the ARC Centre of Excellence for Creative Industries and Innovation,⁸ almost half of Australia's creative workforce work as **'embedded creatives'**, that is, as creative workers who are employed within non-creative industries.⁹

At the same time, creative skills are increasingly discussed as an integral aspect of a **future-focussed skills portfolio**. UK-based policy and research foundation Nesta predicts that jobs requiring creativity are more likely to grow as a percentage

7 Trembath J L and Fielding K 2020, 'Australia's Cultural and Creative Economy: A 21st century guide', produced by A New Approach think tank with lead delivery partner the Australian Academy of the Humanities, Canberra. Bureau of Communications and Arts Research (BCAR) 2020, 'Cultural and Creative Activity in Australia 2008-09 to 2017-18', Explanatory Notes, Canberra: Department of Communications and the Arts. Throsby D and Petetskaya K 2017, *Making Art Work: An economic study of professional artists in Australia*. Bakhshi H, Downing J M, Osborne M A and Schneider P. 2017, *The Future of Skills: Employment in 2030*.

8 Higgs P, Cunningham S and Pagan J 2007, *Australia's Creative Economy: Definitions of the Segments and Sectors*.

9 Trembath J L and Fielding K 2020, 'Australia's Cultural and Creative Economy: A 21st century guide', produced by A New Approach with lead delivery partner the Australian Academy of the Humanities, p. 52 (drawing on figures from the 2016 Census, using the ABS/ BCAR definition of the cultural and creative workforce). SGS Economics & Planning, 2013, *Valuing Australia's Creative Industries Final Report Creative Industries Innovation Centre*. Cunningham S and Higgs P 2009, 'Measuring Creative Employment: Implications for Innovation Policy', *Innovation: Management, Policy and Practice*, 11(2), 190-200.

of the workforce by 2030 than those that do not require creativity.¹⁰ Creativity supports innovation, a crucial element of economic growth in the 21st century.¹¹

Creativity is also frequently identified as key to the kinds of interdisciplinary approaches that will be required in transforming work environments. It therefore has critical utility in the context of contemporary and future work.¹²

Together, these trends point to potential alternative career pathways for creative practitioners, and **the need to prepare creative graduates for future interdisciplinary work.**¹³ But is this how students of creative industries view their future professional role – that is, applying their training in areas beyond their traditional arts discipline or focus? How do potential employers understand the value of creativity or the currency of creative skills? And **what educational models are required to prepare students for complex creative work in interdisciplinary settings?**

This report presents the findings of a joint research project by the Australia Council and QUT's Faculty of Creative Industries that investigated **the role and value of interdisciplinary work integrated learning for creative industries students.** The research focussed on projects run within the QUT School of Creative Practice capstone study program, Situated Creative Practice, as delivered across the program's pilot phase (2019–2020).

Situated Creative Practice students engage with a combination of project-led and problem-based learning approaches¹⁴ that involve **applying their creative capabilities within a specific industry context.** This focuses their attention on developing and delivering creative projects in response to authentic project briefs developed in partnership with industry, while still attending to the continuous development of their own disciplinary practice.

By working alongside industry partners, students are able to **extend their creative and professional networks and develop professional and entrepreneurial approaches to creative practice.** The design of Situated Creative Practice was also intended to equitably increase student access to **authentic, work integrated learning experiences,** which research has indicated has a significant impact on future work success.

Another aim of Situated Creative Practice is to develop students' capacity to identify the specific values of their creative abilities, and find ways to translate and apply these abilities to dynamic problems and contexts. Students are thus required to **apply their disciplinary knowledge and skills to new situations.**

10 Easton E and Djumalieva J 2018, *Creativity and the Future of Skills*.

11 Bridgstock R 2011, 'Making it Creatively: Building sustainable careers in the arts and creative industries', *Australian Career Practitioner Magazine*, 22(2), 11–13. Cunningham S, Theilacker M, Gahan P, Callan V and Rainnie A, 2016, *Skills and Capabilities for Australian Enterprise Innovation*.

12 World Economic Forum 2016, *What are the 21st-Century Skills Every Student Needs?* Ananiadou K and Claro M 2009, '21st Century Skills and Competences for New Millennium Learners in OECD Countries', OECD Education Working Papers, No. 41, OECD Publishing.

13 Foster J and Yaoyuneyong G 2016, 'Teaching Innovation: Equipping students to overcome real-world challenges', *Higher Education Pedagogies*, 1(1), 42–56.

14 Hanney R and Savin-Baden M 2013, 'The problem of projects: understanding the theoretical underpinnings of project-led PBL.' *London Review of Education*, 11(1), 7–19.

By requiring students to situate their specialist creative practice in these ‘real life’ contexts, Situated Creative Practice projects focus on building students’ capacity in creative and critical thinking, problem solving, social intelligence, communication, resource management, and entrepreneurial and technological skills.

The Situated Creative Practice projects therefore seek to prepare students – of dance, drama, writing, music, filmmaking and other traditional arts disciplines – for **careers in more broadly defined creative industries, and potentially for work in sectors that do not necessarily identify with creative or cultural work.** In this way Situated Creative Practice can be considered an alternate approach to developing advanced disciplinary skills within contexts that more closely model those students will work in after graduation. This represents a significant cultural shift in the way students and staff engage within curriculum and with external partners. This report focuses on the initial steps on what will be a much longer journey.

Research purpose and methodology

The Australia Council and QUT have a shared interest in understanding the experiences of those involved in Situated Creative Practice projects, and the challenges, opportunities and learnings encountered in its 2019–20 pilot phase.

This research sits within the Australia Council’s suite of Arts Futures projects that investigate the ways and places that creativity is being deployed and valued, both within and beyond the arts and cultural sector. The Australia Council has an ongoing interest in new areas of employment for artists, and the role and significance of creativity in a rapidly changing society.

For QUT, the project’s reflection upon the Situated Creative Practice program has the potential to yield a better understanding of approaches to interdisciplinary, project-based learning in the creative industries. This understanding will be used to refine QUT’s Situated Creative Practice units and shared for wider learning across both educational and industry sectors.

Students presenting on project work. Credit: Greg Jenkins.



The research focused on seven Situated Creative Practice projects as case studies. It drew on:

- data collected from student assessments and surveys
- 20 semi-structured interviews with Situated Creative Practice students, academics and industry partners.

Collectively, these primary materials captured the opinions, expectations and experiences of a range of people involved in the Situated Creative Practice program, including students, academic staff, industry and community partners.

This research sought to understand:

- Student expectations regarding preparation for professional work in the creative industries.
- Student and staff perceptions of the role and value of the Situated Creative Practice experience in supporting preparedness for professional work in any industry.
- Industry and community partner expectations of work integrated project-based learning and the role and value of interdisciplinary teams.
- Student, staff and industry and community partner perceptions of the benefits and challenges of project-based models of interdisciplinary training.

Parameters of the pilot

The research was conducted during the pilot phase of the Situated Creative Practice projects from August 2019 to June 2020.

For this phase, the interdisciplinary element involved creative practitioners working across arts disciplines, e.g. dancers working with writers and musicians for a film production company seeking to diversify its clientele. These projects asked students to recognise and apply capabilities developed through training in their specific discipline to a wider creative industry context. They also required students to communicate and collaborate with other creative students and professionals in modes that may not be native to their self-identified social world (e.g. the theatre or gallery scene) and/or area of creative expertise.

This is therefore a study of a cross-disciplinary program operating within the creative industries. It explores the ways in which new combinations of creative capabilities can produce creative value, and set artists up for more adaptive and resilient creative careers. Learnings will later translate to cross-industry settings, that is, examples of creative practitioners working in non-creative industries. The researchers will also continue to watch developments in this space, potentially continuing their study of the Situated Creative Practice program as it moves into more cross-sectoral work.

Finally, the pilot was disrupted by COVID-19 in Semester 1 2020, which led to a number of unanticipated outcomes. See page 36 for more on these impacts and adaptations.

The Situated Creative Practice program





Student industry placement at Powerkids: Little Artists at Play, 2019. Credit: FenLan Chuang.

Program background

The Situated Creative Practice program was developed as part of a redesign of the entire Bachelor of Fine Arts at QUT. It was created out of a recognition that, while students often have a strong identification with their discipline (e.g. visual art, drama), **creative industries graduates will work in interdisciplinary teams and many in creative roles not directly related to their specialisation.**

According to the ‘**creative trident**’, developed by the ARC Centre of Excellence for Creative Industries and Innovation,¹⁵ almost half of Australia’s creative workforce work as ‘**embedded creatives**’, that is, as creative workers who are employed within non-creative industries.¹⁶ Data released by the Bureau of Communications and Arts Research in 2020 suggests that the number of embedded creatives grew by nearly 44% in the 10 year period between 2008–09 and 2017–18,¹⁷ making this one of the most rapidly growing segments of the creative economy.¹⁸

2019–20 data collected by QUT¹⁹ presents a similar picture: approximately 40% of graduates from the Bachelor of Fine Arts over the past five years had worked in companies outside the creative industries, yet 80% recognised the relevance of their studies. Analysis of positions and companies shows that many roles held by graduates require an ability to translate capabilities from their area of specialisation into different contexts.

“The change was really to say we think all students doing our degrees need to have this experience, because that’s where the future of the creative field lies – and the skills for the future would come out of that.”

Staff Member

15 Higgs P, Cunningham S and Pagan J 2007, *Australia’s Creative Economy: Definitions of the Segments and Sectors*.

16 SGS Economics & Planning, 2013, *Valuing Australia’s Creative Industries Final Report Creative Industries Innovation Centre*.

Cunningham S and Higgs P 2009, ‘Measuring Creative Employment: Implications for Innovation Policy’, *Innovation: Management, Policy and Practice*, 11(2), 190–200. Trembath J L and Fielding K 2020, ‘Australia’s Cultural and Creative Economy: A 21st century guide’, produced by A New Approach think tank with lead delivery partner the Australian Academy of the Humanities, Canberra.

17 Bureau of Communications and Arts Research 2020, *Cultural and Creative Activity in Australia 2008–09 to 2017–18*, Australian Government, Department of Infrastructure, Transport, Regional Development and Communications.

18 Trembath J L and Fielding K 2020, ‘Australia’s Cultural and Creative Economy: A 21st century guide’, produced by A New Approach think tank with lead delivery partner the Australian Academy of the Humanities, Canberra.

19 In late 2019 QUT undertook a survey of five years of alumni from Creative Industries at QUT. The survey was sent to alumni who graduated from Creative Industries programs between 2014 to 2019, totalling 5590. There was a response rate of 15.85%, while the response rate of Bachelor of Fine Arts graduates was 20%. The survey asked questions about the graduates’ employment, current and previous positions, questions about the relevance of their studies, and context of employment.

However, prospective employers are not necessarily aware of this picture. Through industry consultation, the designers of the Situated Creative Practice program established that while employers have confidence in creative industries graduates' disciplinary skills, there is less awareness of broader graduate capabilities that can be applied within other contexts. For example, **prospective employers lack awareness of graduate capabilities related to interdisciplinary teamwork, business management and entrepreneurialism, complex problem solving, communication, and understanding audiences.**

These are capabilities that are required equally within the cultural and creative industries as in other areas. Thus, the design of Situated Creative Practice recognised the need to publicise and extend students' learning in this area through direct work with industry. It also saw the need to provide an authentic educational experience that prepares graduates for careers that could range from establishing their own creative enterprise²⁰ to working outside the creative industries.

Research on industry clusters²¹ and economic complexity²² shows that **creative value is generated through new combinations of creative capabilities and advances in technology.** This creates a conundrum for creative industries programs that remain within traditional subsectors of 'the arts'. How should programs prepare graduates to work in contexts where the nature of the creative work cannot be reduced to singular disciplines?²³ The design of Situated Creative Practice moves beyond creative practice within a narrowly defined discipline and requires students to apply creative skills in new contexts.

The Situated Creative Practice program was also informed by Bridgstock's model of 'connectedness' learning, and international exemplars.²⁴ The model and exemplars aim to enhance graduate employability through creating meaningful partnerships between the higher education sector, communities and industry.²⁵ This emphasis on situated community and industry learning was fundamental to the program's approach, linking knowledge held across university and professional networks, and extending skills learned in the classroom through workplace experiences. Bridgstock's work, and more recent alumni research,²⁶ indicates that a **connected approach, where students meet and work with industry, improves graduate outcomes.**

20 The alumni survey shows that 40.67% of graduates from the Bachelor of Fine Arts over the past 5 years have established their own creative enterprise. Creative enterprise in the survey was defined broadly from a company to artistic collective or band ensemble etc. This figure was higher than all other programs in the Creative Industries.

21 Comunian R. (n.d.), 'Rethinking the Creative City: The role of Complexity, Networks and Interactions in the Urban Creative Economy'. *Urban Studies*, 48(6), 1157-1179. Cooke P and Lazzeretti L (eds) 2008, *Creative Cities, Cultural Clusters and Local Economic Development*, Cheltenham: Edward Elgar. European Commission 2017, *Clusters in Cultural and Creative Industries*.

22 Hausmann R and Hidalgo C 2013, *The Atlas of Economic Complexity: Mapping paths to prosperity*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: The MIT Press. Potts J 2009, 'Why Creative Industries Matter to Economic Evolution', *Economics of Innovation and New Technology*, 18(7), 663-673.

23 This observation comes from Barry A, Born G and Weszkalnys G 2008, 'Logics of Interdisciplinarity', *Economy and Society*, 37(1), 20-49.

24 McFadyen J and McCullagh J 2015, Design Collaborations: The good, the bad, and the unthinkable. *Design Principles and Practices: An International Journal - Annual Review*, 8(1), 17-29.

25 Bridgstock R 2019, *Higher Education and the Future of Employability: A connectedness learning approach*, Edward Elgar.

26 QUT's graduate survey showed alumni who had completed an Internship (Work Integrated Learning) had 10% better employment outcomes. E.g. approximately 84% of graduates who had not completed an internship were currently employed, while 94% of graduates who completed an internship were currently employed.

Program goal and aims

The overarching goal of the program was **to provide a training ground for interdisciplinary skills development, for work across contexts beyond one traditional art form, and to provide graduates with the capabilities required to work in multidisciplinary creative teams and to support enterprise innovation.**²⁷

Beneath this overall goal sat a **range of interconnected aims for students, the university and industry partners**, including:

- The creation of **a compulsory capstone experience** that was central to the degree, and that signalled the importance of this way of working in professional contexts.
- The creation of an opportunity that was **open to all students**, recognising that it is sometimes only those students with economic or cultural capital or connections that can embark on these kinds of work-based experiences.
- To provide **an opportunity for students to innovate in their creative work, and to open up the space between disciplines**, e.g. moving beyond traditional dance performances to dancers working with robotics.
- Provide **opportunities for graduates to develop unique and relevant works for their portfolio** that will increase the chances of employment in the evolving creative industries.
- To encourage students to develop and **recognise the true value of their transferable skills**, rather than referring to them somewhat disparagingly as ‘soft skills’.
- To create learning experiences that **model the types of professional contexts in which graduates will work** in an authentic way, drawing on external partners to ensure these contexts are aligned with current professional practices.
- To offer these opportunities and partnerships **at scale**, rather than as one-off small projects dotted through the faculty.
- To **strengthen the systems and support for developing and managing partnerships**, providing greater support for industry partners, reducing the burden on individual academics, and increasing support for students should partnerships not work out.
- To create a program that was **highly customisable and able to flex and respond** to the changing circumstances of the creative industries and other sectors.

²⁷ Cunningham S and Higgs P 2009, ‘Measuring Creative Employment: Implications for Innovation Policy’, *Innovation: Management, Policy and Practice*, 11(2), 190–200.

It was this idea that when they graduated, they didn't go out to work in a place called “drama”. And they didn't go out to work in a place called “music”. They'd work in companies or in collectives, as sole traders, or they would work in locations, on sites...

It was about getting them to recognise how they could adapt what they knew to different locations, into different contexts. Working in the sorts of teams that they would be expecting to work in out in the world.

Staff Member



*Alone Together, student creative development work, QUT 2019.
Credit: Kylie Zenchyson.*

Program and course structure

The Situated Creative Practice program is project-based, with each project made up of participants from multiple different study areas within the Bachelor of Fine Arts. This includes, but is not limited to, study areas of acting; animation; creative writing; dance; drama; film, screen and new media; music; technical production; and visual arts.

Situated Creative Practice gives students the opportunity to apply disciplinary knowledge and skills in new situations, extend creative and professional networks, and develop a professional and entrepreneurial approach to creative practice. Students complete up to two 24 credit point creative projects in the final year of their degree. This means that **approximately half of their study time during their final year is spent in multidisciplinary collaborative environments**. While Situated Creative Practice takes place in this final year, it seeks to build on and activate learning undertaken across the previous years of the degree, e.g. lessons in creative and critical thinking, and written and oral communication.

The **learning outcomes and assessment** for Situated Creative Practice require students to focus on the process of interdisciplinary collaboration. Assessment includes **an initial professional plan** through which students are asked to articulate their creative and professional development goals and consider these in respect to an industry project. Alongside the outcome of the project, the final assessment includes **a reflection upon practice, and a professional portfolio** that highlights relevant examples of the student's work in respect to their initial professional plan. In combination, these assessment items draw attention to disciplinary capabilities while also developing a career plan which can inform and guide learning through practice.

During the pilot phase alone, Situated Creative Practice supported **over 30 industry partnerships** and more than **50 creative projects**, preparing **over 450 students** for professional creative practice. Some Situated Creative Practice projects involved students working as embedded creatives and developing creative content for the partner to address a problem or need. Other projects involved students pitching ideas and recommendations to partners.

Many of these projects were arranged with a **single creative outcome** towards which all participants collectively worked. For example, students worked on a public art installation held by the Brisbane City Council called *Botanica: Contemporary Art Outside*.²⁸ Other projects involved larger cohorts working together to achieve **multiple different creative outcomes**. An example of this kind of placement was with record label, Vermilion Records, and through which students contributed a range of ideas and forms of assistance to the company's operations.²⁹

QUT's Faculty of Creative Industries has a range of work integrated learning programs. The Situated Creative Practice projects are only one component of this wider offering – distinguished for their focus on interdisciplinarity.

28 *Botanica: Contemporary Art Outside* is an annual outdoor exhibition held in the City Botanic Gardens. The exhibition aims to inspire conversations about our built, natural and digital environments.

29 Vermilion Records is a not-for-profit, student-run record label based out of Queensland University of Technology in Brisbane, Australia.



Research insights

Theatre Republic, at Kelvin Grove, Brisbane, September 2019.
Site designer Sarah Winter. Credit: Parisa Bong.

Value of participation for students and staff

Summary findings

- **Student responses to the benefits of Situated Creative Practice** during the pilot phase were diverse. While many viewed the program outcomes as critical to their future careers, others were unsure of the value of interdisciplinary work to their development in a specific artistic field.
- **Students' engagement with the principle of 'transferable skills'** and other course concepts increased with art form experience and with time spent in the Bachelor of Fine Arts degree.
- **Staff evaluations of Situated Creative Practice** were also varied. Many staff recognised the value of interdisciplinary work integrated learning. They connected this to perceived improvements in students' communication skills and an enhanced ability for students to enter real-world work settings. However, some staff continued to see the benefit of maintaining specific disciplinary training for the entire duration of the degree.
- **This research requires continual revision and communication to staff and students**, particularly given the rapidly changing professional and educational landscape. Degree-specific research on creative industries graduate pathways and the industry expectations that underpin program design can never be considered 'complete'.



The research sought to understand student and staff perceptions of the role and value of the Situated Creative Practice program in supporting preparation for professional work in the creative industries and beyond.

Both student and staff perceptions were diverse:

First year students expected Situated Creative Practice to build important skills: To understand student expectations prior to undertaking Situated Creative Practice, a survey was conducted at the completion of the Bachelor of Fine Arts foundational units in the first year of study.³⁰ Analysis of the survey responses demonstrated that the stated aims of the Situated Creative Practice were important for students looking to navigate the difficulties of the creative industry – namely, building capacity in creative and critical thinking, problem solving, social intelligence, communication, resource management, and entrepreneurial and technology skills. These capacities were also identified by students as necessary for facing the realities of life as a professional and/or practising artist.³¹

Appreciation of the course concepts increased with art form experience and with time spent in the Bachelor of Fine Arts degree: While many first year students appreciated the Situated Creative Practice goals, some were unsure of how interdisciplinary experience related to them as individual creative practitioners within their respective artistic fields. In the early stage of their Bachelor of Fine Arts degree, while anticipating the Situated Creative Practice experience, many students were unable to engage with the concept of ‘transferable skills’.

Overall, understanding of the benefits of Situated Creative Practice were generally influenced by the degree to which students had progressed through their Bachelor of Fine Arts, and the extent of their art form experience. Those who had studied longer in their chosen discipline demonstrated a stronger appreciation of the benefits of developing skills and capabilities outside ‘core’ disciplinary or artistic skills.

Staff opinions were diverse: Opinions expressed by staff involved in the program were similarly diverse, with some clearly identifying the value of Situated Creative Practice for developing important future skills, and others still unsure of the approach.

Improved communication, work readiness and networks: In a series of in-depth interviews, some Situated Creative Practice teaching staff connected the program’s interdisciplinarity to perceived improvements in students’ communication skills, and an enhanced ability for students to enter professional settings.

A majority of staff involved in the program mentioned the opportunity to learn about other disciplines as key to the value of Situated Creative Practice for students, along with the development of networking and collaboration skills. Giving students an industry experience, and connecting students with a local creative network, were also highlighted as important aspects of the program.

30 KYB101; KYB102, 2019, *Understanding Creative Practice, Pathways to a Creative Career, Student Survey Data*.

31 KYB101; KYB102, 2019, *Understanding Creative Practice, Pathways to a Creative Career, Student Survey Data*.

Supervisors and students saw the rewards of challenging learning experiences: As well as students undertaking Situated Creative Practice, the study surveyed academic project supervisors working on Situated Creative Practice. Both academic staff and students reported that the experience of Situated Creative Practice was challenging compared to a more traditional advanced disciplinary curriculum. Specifically, activities designed to develop workplace skills such as interdisciplinary collaboration and problem solving were often met with a degree of resistance. Extending students beyond their areas of existing expertise also required all project participants to find shared languages for communication.³²

However, rather than these challenges inhibiting learning, they accelerated it. In instances where students were assigned a project of which they had little prior understanding, or which they did not expect to be given, the degree and speed of student learning was perceived to be greater. This observation has been key to understanding the value of the program. It serves as a reminder of the potential of interdisciplinary experiences and the rewards that can come from working beyond one's area of familiarity.

Students' self-identified development needs: Many of the Situated Creative Practice projects required students to outline steps they would take towards the development of 'future focused meta competencies', some of which have been associated with creative employability and career success.³³ This requirement made up part of Situated Creative Practice's formal and informal assessment processes. It also provided valuable insights into students' self-identified needs for development and growth, and an additional data source for this research.

Skill areas highlighted by students as important included written and verbal communication, with 'pitching' practice identified as an area requiring more focussed work. Other areas identified as both significant, and needing more attention within students' development, included collaboration, interdisciplinary working, time management, problem solving and critical and creative thinking.

Skills developed through Situated Creative Practice: Although there was consensus regarding the *need* for skills development in these areas, articulation of the skills *developed* through Situated Creative Practice projects was not consistent across student responses. While some pointed to improved critical thinking skills, or increased familiarity with different disciplinary languages, others were still uncertain about the goals or methods of the course.

The general learnings around collaboration and professionalism are portable for a range of future careers.

Staff Member

³² KYB101; KYB102, 2019, *Understanding Creative Practice, Pulse Student Data*.

³³ Bridgstock R 2011, 'Making it Creatively: Building sustainable careers in the arts and creative industries'. *Australian Career Practitioner Magazine*, 22(2), 11-1.

Staff perceptions of the value of industry connections: Staff referenced the need for students to develop certain forms of industry knowledge and social connections in order to increase their chances of future employment. These knowledges, or ‘industry literacies’, include an understanding of ‘the local scene’, who is who, what trends are in operation, and relationships with key people and organisations. QUT research into Bachelor of Fine Arts graduate careers highlights the value of such industry connections and shows that students undertaking a structured internship during their studies have a 10% greater chance of employment.³⁴ As a strategy for securing future work, these internships were shown to be more effective than other approaches such as volunteering or taking on unpaid work post-graduation.

The need for shared language to articulate the benefits of Situated Creative Practice: As with the students, staff found it simpler to articulate the *need* for specific skills development and knowledge acquisition than to identify the specific skills taught by Situated Creative Practice. However, the difficulty with which students and staff spoke about the benefits of Situated Creative Practice, and the apparent variation across research participants’ experiences and personal evaluations of the program, suggested that there was not yet a shared language for understanding and appraising the Situated Creative Practice model.

Given the scale of student and staff engagement and the breadth of disciplinary specialisations involved in Situated Creative Practice, the establishment of such a shared language will need to be developed over subsequent iterations of the curriculum. Equally, the difference between the research and industry expectations that underpin the program design and long-standing assumptions and preconceptions about the ‘ideal’ creative education come into contestation around a curriculum like Situated Creative Practice.

The kind of ambivalence identified within this research is in fact a common response to organisational change.³⁵ Understanding and discussing this reaction can better prepare teaching staff to embrace the change process. Meanwhile, acknowledging the need for a shared language, and/or a process through which concepts such as ‘transferable skills’ are revised and reinforced in explanations to students and staff of creative industries, can assist others designing similar programs, pointing to some of the translational work involved in establishing interdisciplinary work-based learning.

A changing landscape: Employment conditions for creative industries graduates continues to change, and research into this area requires continual revision. Research must be communicated to staff and students, so that training remains contemporary and relevant.

34 Alumni survey run by QUT’s Creative Industries Faculty in 2019/20.

35 Grimolizzi-Jensen C J 2018, ‘Organizational Change: Effect of motivational interviewing on readiness to change’, *Journal of Change Management*, 18(1), 54–69.

Value of participation for industry partners

Summary findings

- Through participation in the program, industry partners have benefitted from **new skills and fresh ideas** brought to the workplace by students. Contact with students helped industry partners to be part of a community of practice and to **engage with the cutting edge** of artistic practice or creative thinking.
- Participation in Situated Creative Practice has enabled industry partners to **support new entrants to the sector** and ensure that graduates have the right skills when they come to seek employment. For some, this was understood as a means of investing in and **improving the future labour pool**.
- Industry partners also experienced Situated Creative Practice as an **opportunity for brand and relationship building**. By building relationships with future industry entrants, partners also had the opportunity to better establish themselves as a desirable employer.
- Many industry partners **echoed the existing literature on creative industries professional pathways**, pointing to the need for skills such as creative and critical thinking, collaboration, and the importance of being open to new learning experiences.
- Industry partners identified **the need for students to learn about ‘the business’ of the creative sector**. Graduates need an understanding of the local creative scene, common organisational structures, funding models, grant writing, etc.
- Industry partners suggested that **training in a specific art form and relevant technology is also important**. Students should also have an understanding of the theoretical underpinnings of their creative practice.



Students presenting on project work, QUT 2019. Credit: Kylie Zenchyson.

The research sought to understand the perceived value of participation in this form of work integrated learning for the industry partners involved.

Interviews were conducted with partners who worked with students in Situated Creative Practice, and with future potential partners already known to program staff through their involvement in the faculty's broader work integrated learning work. Given the scope of Situated Creative Practice in its pilot phase, most industry interviewees were creative industries professionals who had hosted creative industries students. Others were multidisciplinary organisations or bodies seeking creative outputs or thinking.

Industry interviewees suggested a range of benefits to their organisations of hosting students, including:

Contribution of new skills and fresh ideas: Industry partners reported that both students and the broader QUT partnership brought fresh ideas to their workplace. Industry participants were exposed to new ways of thinking and to an understanding of what creative industries students were learning at university. This allowed industry partners to disrupt how they might approach problems outside normal constraints of government or client regulation. In some cases, this increased digital literacy within the organisation. In others, staff developed their leadership skills through involvement in the program while also experiencing a cross fertilisation of ideas with students.

Supporting new entrants to the sector: Industry interviewees described this form of work integrated learning as a way of supporting new entrants to the sector, and of ensuring that graduates have the right skills when they come to seek employment. This was described as being of benefit to the individual organisation – a way of investing in and improving the available labour pool. However, it was also described as beneficial to the students involved, the other organisations who may employ them and the wider sector ecosystem.

Engaging in the future of their art form: Industry interviewees suggested that working with students enabled them to engage in conversations about the future of their art form. Contact with students helped industry partners to be part of a community of practice and to engage with the cutting edge of artistic practice or creative thinking. This observation was connected to the ways in which students brought fresh ideas to the workplace, and to the value of Situated Creative Practice for supporting new entrants to the sector.

It actually helps our creativity and helps us to be a much more innovative office – and to really test ideas, and get everybody in the office thinking very differently about our design. I think that's the biggest most strategic sort of benefit to the office.

Industry partner

Relationship and brand building: Industry interviewees highlighted that their involvement in this kind of activity delivered benefits to brand-building and the development of future partnerships. By working with a prominent institution such as QUT, partners had the opportunity to share university publicity. By building relationships with future industry entrants, they also had the opportunity to better establish themselves as a desirable employer.

Alternative outcomes: Several industry participants said that hosting Situated Creative Practice students provided them with ideas and options for innovative organisational approaches that they would otherwise not consider or have the capacity to investigate. Compared with other models of work integrated learning, Situated Creative Practice secures more time for students to develop their creative responses to industry requirements. As a result, students have greater agency and involvement in the realisation of authentic outcomes for the industry partner.

Skills required and developed

While the creative industries do require discipline-specific skills, research has identified several other competences as important for creative employability and career success.³⁶ These include digital literacy, an enterprising approach and familiarity with social media.³⁷ Other skills that have been identified as necessary for future creative industries workforces include creative and social skills, transferable skills, emotional intelligence, cross-cultural skills and an openness to lifelong learning.³⁸

Industry partners interviewed for this research echoed these wider findings, pointing to the following required competencies:

- **Career management and career building skills that include resilience, perseverance, self-awareness and agility.** Graduates of creative industries need to be passionate and motivated concerning career goals. They must also be able to adapt, and to make the most of positive chances and negative outcomes.
- **Ability to collaborate and identify the opportunities of interdisciplinary work.** Graduates of creative industries must be able to manage relationships, identify the value and strengths of their own expertise, and communicate ideas across disciplines.
- **Critical and creative thinking skills.** Graduates of creative industries require an ability to think laterally and to approach problems in new ways.
- **Social skills.** Graduates also need to be able to analyse social dynamics, negotiate, and to influence stakeholder expectations.
- **Experience and skills in industry-specific tasks.** These include managing calls for proposals, reviewing exhibitions, research and talking to artists and galleries.
- **Marketing and pitching skills.** Creative industries graduates need strong marketing and pitching skills, enabling them to commercialise their work and stand out in a crowded marketplace, or to add value to somebody else's work.

36 Bridgstock R 2011, 'Making it Creatively: Building sustainable careers in the arts and creative industries', *Australian Career Practitioner Magazine*, 22(2), 11–13.

37 Bridgstock, Ruth 2011, 'Making it Creatively: Building sustainable careers in the arts and creative industries', *Australian Career Practitioner Magazine*, 22(2), 11–13.

38 Throsby D and Petetskaya K 2017, *Making Art Work: An economic study of professional artists in Australia*.

- **Discipline-specific skills that could include technical and art form specific skills.** While students need to combine art form skills with others, disciplinary specific training was also identified as important. However, not all industry participants had realistic expectations of what could be achieved within a three-year bachelor award. One industry participant cited at least 10,000 hours of art practice being required for students to enter the creative workforce. This highlights the challenge educators face in designing programs to meet stated expectations of employers.
- **Willingness and ability to develop new skills on the job.** While some industry participants pointed to perceived gaps in graduate capabilities, they also recognised that graduates were at the beginning of their career and emphasised the need for graduates to be willing to learn. In fact, many participants highlighted the need for graduates to be open to challenges and skills development opportunities such as those provided by Situated Creative Practice.
- **Discipline specific industry knowledge and networks.** Creative industries graduates require an understanding of relevant organisational structures, budgets, risks, funding models, budgets, grant writing, and where to find legal resources for their specific industry. They also benefit from connections to the 'local scene'.
- **Understanding future trends that will impact the sector.** This is crucial. In recognising the value of engaging with students through Situated Creative Practice, industry participants commented on the need for graduates to be able to identify creative opportunities resulting from the impact of future trends on the sector.



Dance 19, QUT 2019. Credit: Tony Phillips.

Challenges of program development

Summary findings

A number of challenges were encountered in this pilot stage of Situated Creative Practice.

- **For staff**, these were:
 - **Managing student expectations** of their university experience and future careers alongside the actual requirements of professional creative practice.
 - **Ensuring all stakeholders feel mutually invested** in the program.
 - **Countering perceptions** among some staff and students that the program might reduce students' capacities to **continue their discipline-based arts training**.
 - **Communicating the importance of Situated Creative Practice** in a way that is both consistent and responsive to different art form requirements.
 - **Integrating information and processes** across a large range of specialised university systems to enable innovations in curriculum design and program delivery.
- **For industry partners**, these were:
 - **Limitations on organisational capacity** to take on Situated Creative Practice projects.
 - **Difficulty providing meaningful opportunities** for students that align with the aims of the program.
 - **Difficulty developing realistic opportunities** for students given the project cycles of the organisation.
 - **Limits on student preparedness** to undertake project-based experiences.

Challenges identified by Situated Creative Practice staff

Managing student expectations of their university experience and future careers alongside the actual requirements of professional creative practice

A recent survey of first year students in QUT's Bachelor of Fine Arts overwhelmingly identified self-expression as the main motivator for doing the degree. This suggests a very personal relationship with creative practice.³⁹ Market research conducted as part of the redevelopment of the degree in 2017 showed that Bachelor of Fine Arts students commenced their studies with a strong creative identity aligned to a specific discipline. Course coordinators interviewed for this research have also suggested that it is important that students have sufficient confidence in their creative identities, capabilities and contribution before moving on to work in interdisciplinary contexts.

³⁹ KYB101; KYB102, 2019, *Understanding Creative Practice, Pathways to a Creative Career Pulse Student Data*.

One challenge in the Situated Creative Practice program has been to avoid damaging this love of an art form while widening students' understanding and experiences to a more realistic view of future opportunities and realities. Successful practitioners are often required to show flexibility while simultaneously maintaining and managing their own career path. For example, they need to respond to opportunities at short notice, apply their knowledge and skills in a range of contexts, respond to the needs of industry or community, and work on diverse projects with complex interdisciplinary teams.⁴⁰

Ensuring all stakeholders feel mutually invested in the Situated Creative Practice program

A related difficulty in instituting the Situated Creative Practice program has been securing investment among academic teaching staff and ensuring widespread understanding of the relevance of the program to future creative industries careers.

Challenges with curriculum change are not uncommon, and the designers of the Situated Creative Practice program understood that support from academic staff would be critical. Despite this, the program designers soon learned that the scale of the change process was greater than initially anticipated, requiring even greater buy-in than expected. Both students and staff required extra support in the change process, specifically in the shift from a focus on traditional arts disciplines to the use of art form skills in alternative contexts.

While some compromises were required to ensure all stakeholders maintained a sense of connection to the program, this challenge came to be understood as a natural part of the development process. To an extent, this is the nature of collaborative, creative work, and outcomes can rarely be guaranteed in advance. As a consequence, not all projects fully realised the intended outcomes of the program in the pilot phase.

Countering perceptions that Situated Creative Practice might reduce students' capacities to continue their discipline-based arts training

The design of Situated Creative Practice aimed to provide new and more relevant contexts in which students could develop and practice their discipline-specific skills. However, some academic teaching staff were concerned that Situated Creative Practice would take valuable time from art form-specific education during the final year of students' degrees.

The intention of Situated Creative Practice was not to reduce disciplinary practice, but rather to find a different site for it to occur, and to guide students in how to adapt and apply it in professional contexts. The challenge was as much one of communication among academic stakeholders as it was of actual curriculum content.

This challenge has arisen in other institutions. McFaden and McCullagh note the tension between subject expertise and 'fostering an environment of cross-subject pollination'. They focus on 'being collaborative' as a way to address these tensions.⁴¹ They also observe staff anxieties related to a 'loss of control and ownership and the risk of letting go of subject specificity and finally allowing students to own the direction of learning'. In the context of Situated Creative Practice, students were also anxious about entering a program which gave them an increased level of control over charting their learning journey and defining creative and professional goals.

40 Situated Creative Practice Unit Information accessed 31 August 2020 <https://www.qut.edu.au/study/unit?unitCode=KYB301>.

41 McFadyen J and McCullagh J 2015, 'Design Collaborations: The good, the bad, and the unthinkable', *Design Principles and Practices: An International Journal - Annual Review*, 8(1). 17-29.

Communicating the importance of Situated Creative Practice in a way that is both consistent and responsive to specific art form requirements

It was important that the overall framework of Situated Creative Practice could be clearly and consistently communicated to students and staff across all projects and disciplinary backgrounds. For example, student and staff workloads, learning outcomes, and assessment tasks all needed to be clearly defined, but also needed to take account of individual project timelines and disciplinary terminologies. To do this, the unit coordinators worked individually with each project supervisor to customise the presentation of unit information for each project.

The tension between consistency of overall unit requirements and project specifics sometimes led to inconsistencies in how the unit information was presented to students. For example, in projects with tangible, pre-figured disciplinary outcomes, students and staff tended to view the quality of the project outcome as the principal purpose of Situated Creative Practice. They viewed the planning and reflection tasks as more peripheral requirements. By contrast, in projects where the precise form of the outcome was more emergent, the planning and reflection tasks might be cast as more integral to the collaborative development and production processes.

Integrating information and processes across a large range of specialised university systems to enable innovations in curriculum design and program delivery

Bringing multiple creative disciplines together to work on projects was operationally challenging, and in some ways worked counter to existing school structures and systems. For example, where projects involved students from multiple disciplines, it was advantageous to have academics from each discipline acknowledged as stakeholders in the project to ensure students could be appropriately supported.

The challenge of scaling the program within university systems and processes was also significant. For example it was necessary to promote project opportunities to students prior to their enrolment in the multiple Situated Creative Practice unit codes so that they could make informed choices about which project they wished to submit an expression of interest for. Identifying and communicating with students eligible to apply for the projects required academic staff to analyse course progression reports and effectively mount an internal marketing and recruitment campaign. This required the unit coordinators to manually integrate university curriculum management systems, work integrated learning management systems and learning management systems. Strategies to communicate with students included personalised email campaigns, social media campaigns, and the development of mobile device applications.

The pilot phase also occurred though a period of change within the university, and most notably was impacted by COVID-19 in the first half of 2020. Although university structures and systems can be perceived as resistant to change, the ability of the university to implement Situated Creative Practice amidst such disruptions demonstrates that significant transformation can be achieved at pace within the tertiary sector. In this case, transformation was made possible through the knowledgeable integration of existing structures and systems.

The challenges of integrating the priorities of industry and academic contexts was also mentioned consistently throughout the research. Most frequently, these challenges manifest as misalignment of academic timelines with industry priorities. The advent of COVID-19 also saw some industry partners reduce their engagement with students as they concentrated on their own business continuity plans.

Challenges identified by Situated Creative Practice industry partners

As Situated Creative Practice was in its pilot phase, industry interviewees also drew on their broader experience of hosting students for work integrated learning experiences. The challenges raised included:

Limitations on organisational capacity to take on Situated Creative Practice projects

Interviewees were concerned that as small and medium sized organisations they do not always have the capacity (people, time and skills) to support students adequately. Some industry participants reported that additional support from staff during the project was needed to mentor or support students.

Providing meaningful opportunities that align with the Situated Creative Practice aims

Connected to organisational capacity was the challenge of being able to offer students projects and opportunities that were meaningful. They needed to be intensive enough to enable the students to gain useful experience and develop valuable skills. These more meaningful experiences were perceived as more time consuming for organisations. But they were also seen as having the potential to deliver stronger outcomes for both students and industry partners. Several industry research participants argued that time should be invested to ensure that Situated Creative Practice projects are aligned to the core strategic goals of the organisation. The management of student expectations undertaking the projects were also highlighted.

Developing realistic opportunities for students given the project cycles of the organisation

Industry partners suggested it could be challenging to develop project opportunities with students that were realistic and in line with project cycles in their organisation or department. It was challenging to find tasks that were appropriate for the organisation, appropriate to student capabilities, and fitting within organisational and university timescales.

Staff and students of Situated Creative Practice. Credit: Kylie Zenchyson.



Theatre Republic at Kelvin Grove, Brisbane, September 2019. Credit: Parisa Bong.

Student preparedness to undertake project-based experiences

Some interviewees questioned whether the broader undergraduate program prepared students adequately for work integrated, project-based experiences. Several industry participants expressed that students should come to the placement with some idea of what the industry is about, and the ecosystem in which the industry partner sits.

One of the biggest identified challenges was managing student expectations and knowledge. Many students commencing Situated Creative Practice did not have a good idea of the level of bureaucracy or complexity that is associated with some industry and community placements. This observation in part reinforces the approach of Situated Creative Practice, which builds connections between university and industry, and develops learning experiences which more closely model the types of work setting students enter into after graduation. It also suggests a need for more exposure to industry throughout the degree to expand students' understanding of the broader ecosystem in which the creative industry sits.





Successes of program development

Summary findings

Successes of program development were:

- The production of strong advocates for the program within QUT.
- Ability of the Situated Creative Practice projects to fit within and inform the wider Bachelor of Fine Arts program.
- Suitability of the program for students with existing industry experience in particular.
- Extension and development of existing partnerships between industry and the university.
- Flexibility and adaptability of the program, particularly in the context of the COVID-19 pandemic.

Program staff, students and industry partners identified a range of successes they felt had supported the Situated Creative Practice pilot program:

The production of strong advocates for the program within the university

As outlined above, many challenges encountered during the program's development related to the difficulty of achieving buy-in from students, teaching staff and industry partners. At the same time, many research participants within the school recognised the value in what Situated Creative Practice was working to deliver. This was particularly the case for those with recent experience working in the creative sector.

Similarly, the pilot program encountered some difficulties in translating the purpose and methods of Situated Creative Practice to industry partners. In other instances, this research presented examples of how the program can build strong advocates externally through the development of meaningful partnerships between university and industry.

The ability for Situated Creative Practice to fit within a whole course perspective

Another success of the program was the ability for the Situated Creative Practice to be fit within a whole course perspective, supported by first year modules which aim to develop creative and critical literacy early in the students' university experience and provide a foundation for this work in the third year.

At present, the second year of the Bachelor of Fine Arts degree is almost entirely discipline-focussed, and the development of interdisciplinary literacies can vary depending on the area of study. Further development and implementation of Situated Creative Practice would provide the opportunity for greater consistency across these different cohorts and classes, introducing the language and logics of interdisciplinarity throughout the three-year degree.

Suitability of the program for students with existing industry experience

Research participants noted that the introduction of these course components from year one was particularly suitable for students with existing industry experience. These students had an easy understanding of the course design, and the purpose behind its structure.

As one research participant said:

'The students have changed over time. When I went through creative training, we would be encouraged to think of ourselves as in a chrysalis ... you're growing, you're a ... developing creative. And then graduation would happen and you would be launched into the world as a beautiful butterfly.'

That's not the way that [many of] our students relate to the world. They are often putting their work out there, and themselves as creatives, before they even come to us at university. They've had a profile of some kind online; they've had social media from when they were 16 or 15.

So actually it's too late to wait till the end of their degree to start talking to them about, "How do you present yourself?" "How do you structure your career goals?" Because they kicked that off before we even met them.'

Students who had worked in the industry already, or who had developed a profile as an independent creator, often had a working knowledge of the local scene, and a strong appreciation of the value of networks and networking abilities.

Extension and development of existing partnerships between industry and the university

Despite challenges with attracting non-creative industry partners, and the difficulties of maintaining stability with others, there were a limited number of strong industry partnerships already established with the university and on which the team were able to draw in developing opportunities for students. Communication between the university and industry partners was seen as effective and supporting the placement process.

Situated Creative Practice students. Credit: Greg Jenkins.



Flexibility and adaptability of the program, particularly in the context of the COVID-19 pandemic

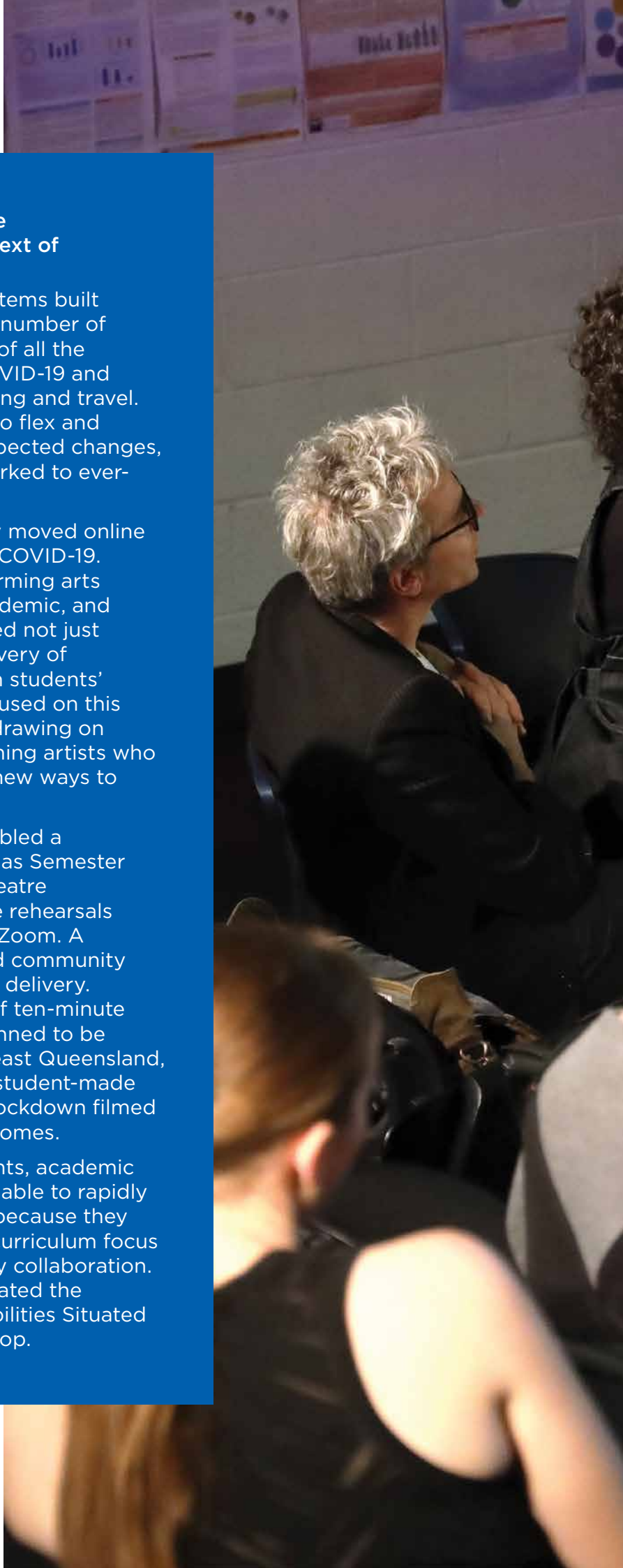
Finally, the infrastructure and systems built around the program withstood a number of shocks and challenges, not least of all the disruptions brought about by COVID-19 and associated restrictions on gathering and travel. The program structure was able to flex and accommodate a number of unexpected changes, its projects being creatively reworked to ever-changing conditions.

Situated Creative Practice rapidly moved online in Semester 1 2020 as a result of COVID-19. Externally the creative and performing arts did not fare well through the pandemic, and the teaching team were concerned not just for the immediate impact on delivery of Situated Creative Practice, but on students' futures. In response the team focused on this as an opportunity for learning – drawing on examples of creative and performing artists who successfully adapted and found new ways to sustain their careers.

The flexibility of the program enabled a reimagining of project outcomes as Semester 1 progressed. A traditional live theatre production was shifted to remote rehearsals and performances facilitated via Zoom. A series of participatory, arts-based community workshops were moved to online delivery. And in another example, a slate of ten-minute documentary films, originally planned to be filmed on-site throughout Southeast Queensland, was transformed into a series of student-made documentaries on life in COVID lockdown filmed remotely in students' individual homes.

In each of these instances, students, academic staff, and industry partners were able to rapidly adjust the outcomes of projects because they were supported by a consistent curriculum focus on the process of interdisciplinary collaboration. In this way, the crisis has accentuated the importance of the types of capabilities Situated Creative Practice set out to develop.

Staff and students discussing project work with Industry partner. Credit: Kylie Zenchyson.





Conclusions

Interdisciplinary project-based curricula run at the scale of the Situated Creative Practice program present a series of challenges and opportunities. This research serves as an important set of initial learnings about interdisciplinary project-based learning within the creative industries.

Research into careers and industry expectations point to the demand for 21st century skills and interdisciplinary project-based approaches with stronger industry connections. However, there remains a need to translate the importance of such an approach to students and staff.

The introduction of Situated Creative Practice represents a significant cultural shift in the practices of education in creative fields. It asks staff and students alike to question what constitutes a site for learning, and the assumed career pathways within creative disciplines.

Many of the industry partners interviewed for this research identified the benefits and value of interdisciplinary work integrated learning. Meanwhile, many young people invested in the idea of a particular artist identity are still ambivalent about the value of the program.

The disciplinary structures of the university, and education more broadly, can make programs like Situated Creative Practice more challenging to introduce. However, this research has shown the value of such interdisciplinary programs, especially in terms of the capabilities that are developed through creative, project-based work. This value is grounded in experiences of collaboration. It is also grounded in the development of new kinds of partnerships that recognise the benefits of creativity for a wide range of contexts.

While there remains a need for discipline-specific depth (skill within art form) among the teaching staff, there is also a need for teaching staff to provide learning support for future-focussed skills *between* art forms and *outside* the arts. This includes collaboration and the ability to work in interdisciplinary settings. The Situated Creative Practice experience suggests that there is **real benefit to purposefully and explicitly teaching collaborative skills and technologies, rather than assuming these as tacit knowledges.**

Key lessons learned during the pilot phase of the Situated Creative Practice program at QUT indicate that there is **a need to focus on ways to translate between different organisational lexicons**. This includes both translating the values, practices, and skills of creative industries into the languages of other sectors, as well as translating the languages of specific art forms into a language of the creative industries more generally. Future programs would benefit by recognising this capability to translate values between different sectors and systems as a fundamental requirement for the program's success. **It is also imperative that academic staff in charge of such programs model this type of transdisciplinarity within their own institutions**, so as to broker value between academic staff, other university staff, industry partners and students.

Current research into careers and the creative industries highlights the importance of being able to transfer skills to new contexts and of being able to describe the value of creativity to diverse sectors. There is less research on how to do this in practice, within the curriculum and at scale.

This report reflects on an experience in which interdisciplinary project-based units were incorporated within a traditional Bachelor of Fine Arts. Many of its insights are early observations. This is a study of a pilot program, and we recognise that this work represents the beginning of a longer process of cultural change.

However, by outlining lessons learned and recommendations as identified by students, staff and industry partners involved in Situated Creative Practice at QUT, we hope to provide direction for the growing number of educators embarking on interdisciplinary project-based learning for students of the creative industries.



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